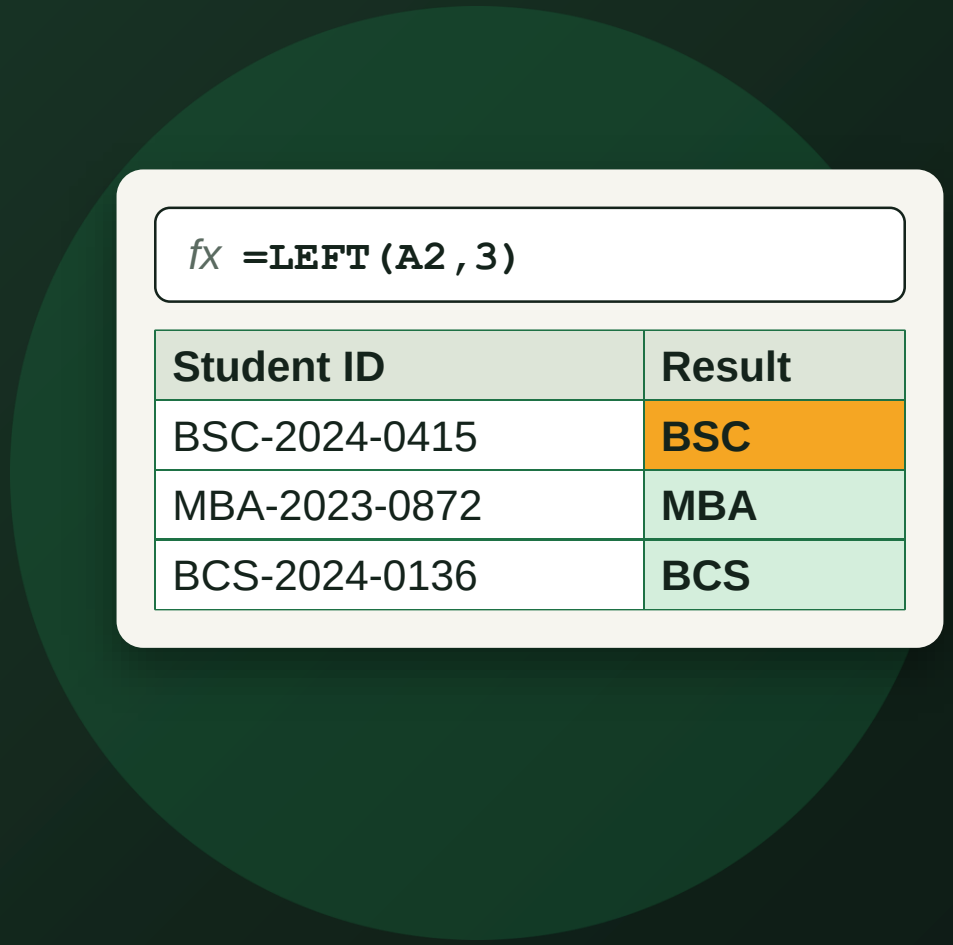
UNIT 9.1

Extracting Text

`LEFT` `RIGHT` `MID`

Learn it, try it, check it



Slides by Sir M Khan Jamali

THEORY · WHAT IT IS

What does extracting mean?

Extracting means taking a **part** of the text in a cell and using it somewhere else.

CELL A2 HOLDS THIS TEXT

B	O	X	-	2	0	2	6	-	C	9
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11

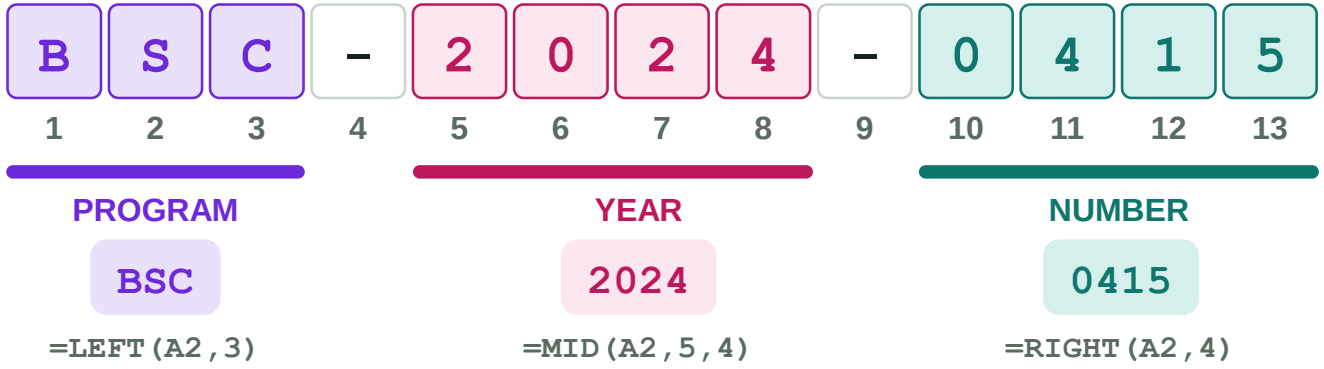
Each box is a **character**. The number under it is its **position**.

`=LEFT(A2,3)` → `BOX` `=MID(A2,5,4)` → `2026` `=RIGHT(A2,2)` → `C9`

THEORY · WHY IT IS NEEDED

Why do we need to extract text?

ONE CELL HOLDS THREE FACTS. EXTRACT EACH ONE INTO ITS OWN COLUMN.



Codes
Read a program, a year or a number

Names
Take a first name or an initial

Data
Split one long cell into columns

THEORY · THE PATTERN

The three slots

	TEXT	START	COUNT	
LEFT	A2	none	3	=LEFT(A2,3)
RIGHT	A2	none	2	=RIGHT(A2,2)
MID	A2	5	4	=MID(A2,5,4)

> The **text** comes first. Only MID has a **start**. Last comes how many **characters**.

TOPIC 1 OF 3

LEFT: take characters from the start

READ IT

`=LEFT(A2,3)`

`A2` the text

`3` how many characters

IN EXCEL

A2	BOX-2026-C9	→	B2	BOX

TEXT IN A2

B	O	X	-	2	0	2	6	-	C	9
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11

first 3

`=LEFT(A2,3)` → `BOX`

S	a	r	a	·	A	h	m	e	d
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10

`=LEFT(A2,4)` → `Sara`

Use it for: codes, prefixes and first names.

Watch out: the count is fixed, so every cell gets the same number of characters.

TOPIC 2 OF 3

RIGHT: take characters from the end

READ IT

```
=RIGHT(A2,2)
```

A2 the text

2 how many characters

IN EXCEL

A2	BOX-2026-C9	→	B2	C9

TEXT IN A2

B	O	X	-	2	0	2	6	-	C	9
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11

last 2

```
=RIGHT(A2,2)  →  C9
```

S	a	r	a	·	A	h	m	e	d
1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10

```
=RIGHT(A2,5)  →  Ahmed
```

Use it for: endings such as last digits, batches and surnames.

Watch out: RIGHT counts from the end, not from position 1.

TOPIC 3 OF 3

MID: take characters from the middle

READ IT

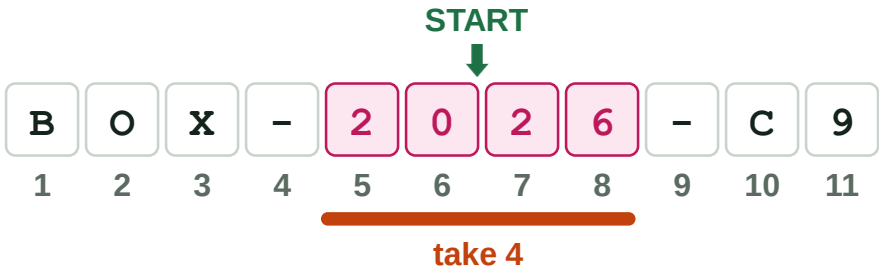
`=MID(A2,5,4)`

- **A2** the text
- **5** where to start
- **4** how many characters

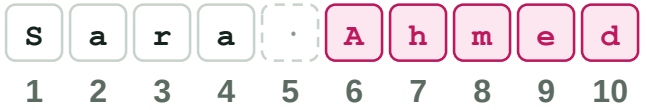
IN EXCEL

A2 `BOX-2026-C9` → B2 `2026`

TEXT IN A2



`=MID(A2,5,4)` → `2026`



`=MID(A2,6,5)` → `Ahmed`

Use it for: years, areas and codes in the centre.

Watch out: spaces count as characters.

PRACTICE · WORK ALONE, THEN COMPARE WITH A PARTNER

Practice: student IDs

TYPE THIS TABLE INTO A NEW SHEET

	A	B	C	D	E	F
1	**Student ID**	**Name**	**Program**	**Year**	**Number**	**Initial**
2	BSC-2024-0415	Ali Khan				
3	MBA-2023-0872	Sara Ahmed				
4	BCS-2024-0136	Omar Shah				
5	MSC-2022-0599	Hina Malik				

1. Program: the first 3 characters.
2. Year: from position 5, take 4.
3. Number: the last 4 characters.
4. Initial: the first letter of Name.
5. Change A2's year. What updates?
6. In G: Surname with MID from 5. Fits all?

REMEMBER `=LEFT(text,count)` `=RIGHT(text,count)` `=MID(text,start,count)`

Bonus: class list

TYPE THIS TABLE INTO A NEW SHEET

	A	B	C	D	E
1	**Student ID**	**Program**	**Year**	**New?**	**Label**
2	BCS-2024-0215				
3	BCS-2023-0384				
4	MBA-2024-0127				

1. Program: the first 3 characters.
2. Year: from position 5, take 4.
3. New?: New if Year is 2024, else Old.
4. Label: join Program and Year with &.
5. Insert a row above row 3: a new ID.
6. AutoFit all. Hide column A.

REMEMBER `=LEFT(text,count)` `=RIGHT(text,count)` `=MID(text,start,count)`

Answers

PRACTICE · MID(B2,5,4) FITS ALI KHAN ONLY: THE OTHER SURNAMES START WITH A SPACE (SHOWN AS A DOT)

Student ID	Name	Program	Year	Number	Initial	Surname
Row 2 formula		`=LEFT(A2,3)`	`=MID(A2,5,4)`	`=RIGHT(A2,4)`	`=LEFT(B2,1)`	`=MID(B2,5,4)`
BSC-2024-0415	Ali Khan	BSC	2024	0415	A	Khan
MBA-2023-0872	Sara Ahmed	MBA	2023	0872	S	·Ahm
BCS-2024-0136	Omar Shah	BCS	2024	0136	O	·Sha
MSC-2022-0599	Hina Malik	MSC	2022	0599	H	·Mal

BONUS · MID GIVES TEXT, SO COMPARE WITH "2024" IN QUOTES

Student ID	Program	Year	New?	Label
Row 2 formula	`=LEFT(A2,3)`	`=MID(A2,5,4)`	`=IF(C2="2024","New","Old")`	`=B2&" "&C2`
BCS-2024-0215	BCS	2024	New	BCS 2024
BCS-2023-0384	BCS	2023	Old	BCS 2023
MBA-2024-0127	MBA	2024	New	MBA 2024